

Creative Solutions & Difficult Conversations

Myth Busting

- Creativity is for artists. Creativity is not just for art but actually for anybody who needs to come up with solutions to issues in their everyday lives.
- Often times people view creativity as genetic. This is not true. The best creative solutions come from those bold and brave enough to believe that there is a better way and who question the world around them.
- Not allowing ourselves to take work breaks or strategic distraction periods will result in quicker and better solutions. Again, simply not true. We often hit an impasse when it comes to tasks and working through them just for the sake of completion. This can hold us back from excellent work.
- If a difficult conversation scares us then we should avoid it. This is a mistake as when we overemphasize our short-term emotions at the expense of our long-term happiness and the happiness of those around us then we may avoid important work and personal conversations. In effect by trying to protect ourselves short term we may actually be causing ourselves great anxiety and stress in the long-term.

Useful Thought Experiments For Better Decisions

- The next time you have a difficult decision to make which needs a quick response, ask yourself, what would I advise my friend to do in this situation given they have told me all the details?
- If you know that you are avoiding an important conversation then ask yourself, "how will I feel 10-minutes, 10-months and 10-years after having this conversation?"
- This may help you to see if you are overvaluing your short-term desire for harmony instead of a longer-term sense of peace and truth.
- If you feel like you have an important decision to make and there appear to be only 2-options on the table then ask yourself am I missing a creative third solution?
- When you feel pressed to buy something online or in-person, slow down and ask yourself, "do I feel completely comfortable with this? If not, could I give myself a few hours to reassess". German researchers have actually shown that we are better at spotting liars once we have stepped out of the situation and can look back at it from a distance.

What To Do When You Have Hit A Creative Impasse

- Give yourself permission to step away from the task. Beethoven used to go for walks, Einstein played the violin and Woody Allen would go for a shower in order to spike their productivity and creative thinking.

